

Ten paths, what each one turns you into, and what it pays.

One page per path: what the degree teaches, the job titles it actually leads to, and the money — with the source and the confidence attached to every figure.

Read this before you read a single salary number

Salary aggregators disagree with each other by up to 2× on the same role, country and year. Sound designer in Germany came back as €33,810 (PayScale), €52,141 (ERI) and €58,446 (SalaryExpert). Marketing manager in the Netherlands came back as €54,130 (PayScale) and €100,432 (SalaryExpert). These are not different roles. They are the same role measured by sites with different, mostly self-selected samples.

So this document does three things instead of pretending to precision: it **prints the spread rather than an average**, because averaging two numbers that differ by 2× manufactures a confidence neither has; it **labels every figure with its source and a confidence badge**; and it **anchors everything to national medians**, which come from statistical offices and recruiter placement data and are the only genuinely solid numbers here.

The anchors — trust these first

BENCHMARK	GROSS PER YEAR	SOURCE	CONFIDENCE
Berlin — all occupations, gross median	€56,500	StepStone Gehaltsreport 2026	solid
Netherlands — all occupations, gross average	€53,436	CBS / national average 2026	solid
Spain — software engineer, 0–2 years	€20,000 – €28,000	Michael Page / Manfred salary guide 2026 (Spain)	solid
Spain — software engineer, 3–6 years	€32,000 – €50,000	Michael Page / Manfred salary guide 2026 (Spain)	solid
Berlin — IT software developer	€45,500 – €63,800 (avg €53,400)	StepStone Gehaltsreport 2026	solid
Berlin — data scientist	€50,400 – €69,700 (avg €59,400)	StepStone Gehaltsreport 2026	solid

The country effect dwarfs the path effect. The same software role pays roughly **€20–28k starting in Spain** and **€45–64k in Berlin** — a gap far larger than any difference between these ten paths. Spain's low tuition and low salary are the same fact seen twice. Berlin gives you free tuition *and* the higher salary, which is why it keeps winning on the shortlist; the price is German.

All ten at a glance

	PATH	TYPICAL FIRST JOB	BERLIN BAND	SALARY-DATA QUALITY
A	Sound & Music Computing	Audio software / DSP engineer	€45,500 – €63,800	solid
C	AI / ML for Audio & Music	ML engineer (audio / speech)	€50,400 – €69,700	solid
N	Music-Tech Product & Innovation	Product manager / product engineer	€53,000 – €70,000 in product roles	indicative
G	Sound Design (film / games / media)	Sound designer — film, TV, games	€33,810 – €58,446 — sources disagree by 73%	weak
H	Immersive / Spatial Audio	Spatial audio engineer	€45,000 – €65,000	indicative
R	Live Sound & Event Systems	Live sound engineer (FOH / monitors)	no reliable figure retrieved	no data
J	Music Business & Management	Label manager / A&R	no reliable European figures found	no data
L	Music / Creative Entrepreneurship	Founder — label, studio, product, agency	no salaried benchmark — income is what the venture earns	no data
AC	Marketing & Brand Management	Marketing analyst → marketing manager	€38,442 – €55,000 entry · €54,130 average	indicative
AD	Media & Entertainment Management	Media / content operations manager	€40,000 – €60,000	weak

Where the money and the music actually overlap

Three roles pay engineering money and are genuinely about sound: **audio DSP / plug-in engineer** (path A), **ML engineer for audio or speech** (path C), and **technical sound designer** in games (path G — Wwise/FMOD plus code). All three are scarce specialisms inside well-paid professions, which is the rare combination.

You do not have to choose between earning and making music. You do have to choose the *technical* half of the music industry rather than the creative half, because that is where the pay is and where your degree already puts you.

Where the numbers simply do not exist

Path J (music business) — no reliable European salary data was found at all. The figures circulating online are US-denominated and do not transfer. That opacity is itself informative: unpublished pay is usually lower and more variable than the public US numbers suggest.

Path L (entrepreneurship) — there is no salary, by design. Income is whatever the venture earns, and employed cultural-sector roles sit below the national medians.

Path R (live sound) — no figure retrieved, and no viable master's exists in scope regardless. It is a certification-and-experience field, not a degree field.

Sound & Music Computing

What you would actually learn

- Digital signal processing: filters, FFT, convolution, real-time constraints
- Audio programming in C++ and Python — JUCE, plug-in formats, latency budgets
- Psychoacoustics: what the ear actually perceives, and what you can therefore discard
- Music information retrieval: beat tracking, transcription, source separation
- A thesis that is usually half software, half experiment

What job you end up doing

Audio software / DSP engineer	Plug-ins, audio engines, embedded audio. The role your degree points at most directly.
Music-tech R&D engineer	Ableton, Native Instruments, Bose, Dolby, Sonos, Spotify's audio team.
MIR / machine-listening engineer	Recommendation, tagging, stem separation, detection.
Research assistant → PhD	If you want the research route, this is where it starts.

What it pays

Berlin	€45,500 – €63,800	solid
StepStone Gehaltsreport 2026 — high — DSP roles sit at or above the general developer band, ~€55–58k reported		
Netherlands	€50,000 – €85,000	indicative
aggregator (PayScale / SalaryExpert / ERI / Glassdoor) — medium — sources spread widely; treat the top of the range as senior/big-tech		
Spain	€20,000 – €28,000 start • €32,000 – €50,000 at 3–6 yrs	solid
Michael Page / Manfred salary guide 2026 (Spain) — high		

The honest verdict

The strongest earnings path in this list AND the best subject fit. Audio DSP is a scarce specialism inside a well-paid profession — you are not trading money for music.

AI / ML for Audio & Music

What you would actually learn

- Machine learning proper: architectures, training, evaluation, deployment
- Deep learning for sequences and spectrograms
- Data engineering — the part of the job that is actually most of the job
- A thesis you can point at audio if a lab exists (UGR's SigMAT, UPF's MTG)

What job you end up doing

ML engineer (audio / speech)	Speech recognition, voice synthesis, generative audio.
Data scientist / ML engineer, general	The fallback that pays well anywhere — and hires constantly.
Research engineer at an audio lab	Sony CSL, Spotify, Deezer, ElevenLabs-type companies.

What it pays

Berlin	€50,400 – €69,700	solid
StepStone Gehaltsreport 2026 — high — the best-paid band found in Berlin		
Netherlands	€55,000 – €100,000+	weak
aggregator (PayScale / SalaryExpert / ERI / Glassdoor) — low — aggregators quote €101k averages that do not match graduate reality; the CBS national average is €53k		
Spain	€25,000 – €35,000 start; AI commands a premium	indicative
Michael Page / Manfred salary guide 2026 (Spain) — medium		

The honest verdict

Highest ceiling and the most portable. The risk is drifting away from audio entirely — the degree will not keep you in music, only a deliberate thesis and portfolio will.

Music-Tech Product & Innovation

What you would actually learn

- Prototyping and user research — building to learn, not to ship
- Interaction and product design method
- Business modelling, validation, pitching
- A capstone that is usually a real product with real users

What job you end up doing

Product manager / product engineer	Music-tech startups, hardware, apps.
Interaction / UX engineer	Where design meets code.
Founder	The path several of these programmes are explicitly built for.

What it pays

Berlin	€53,000 – €70,000 in product roles	indicative
	aggregator (PayScale / SalaryExpert / ERI / Glassdoor) — medium — sits near the developer band, higher with equity	
Netherlands	€45,000 – €75,000	indicative
	aggregator (PayScale / SalaryExpert / ERI / Glassdoor) — medium	
Spain	€25,000 – €40,000	indicative
	Michael Page / Manfred salary guide 2026 (Spain) — medium	

The honest verdict

Pays slightly less than pure engineering at the start and more later, IF the venture works. It is the only path where the upside is uncapped and the downside is real.

Sound Design (film / games / media)

What you would actually learn

- Sound design craft: recording, editing, foley, layering to picture
- Mixing and delivery standards for broadcast, cinema and games
- Middleware — Wwise, FMOD — and interactive audio systems
- A reel. This path is judged on the reel, permanently

What job you end up doing

Sound designer — film, TV, games	Project or staff work; games are the more stable employer.
Re-recording mixer / audio post engineer	Studio-based, credit-driven, freelance-heavy.
Technical sound designer (games)	The hybrid role your engineering makes you unusually good at — Wwise/FMOD plus code.

What it pays

Germany	€33,810 – €58,446 — sources disagree by 73% aggregator (PayScale / SalaryExpert / ERI / Glassdoor) — LOW. PayScale says €33,810, ERI says €52,141, SalaryExpert says €58,446, for the same role and year. ERI's entry level is €38,138	weak
Netherlands	€50,220 sound designer · €62,799 sound engineer aggregator (PayScale / SalaryExpert / ERI / Glassdoor) — low — single-source, aggregator	weak
Spain	not researched — the Spanish figure was not retrieved — — none	no data

The honest verdict

The widest pay uncertainty of any path here, and the most freelance exposure. Technical sound design is the sub-role where your engineering converts into money; pure creative sound design competes against a large pool that will out-portfolio you.

Immersive / Spatial Audio

What you would actually learn

- Ambisonics, binaural rendering, wave field synthesis
- Room and environmental acoustics, measurement and modelling
- Object-based audio formats and production for Atmos and XR
- Heavy maths and physics — the most technically demanding path here

What job you end up doing

Spatial audio engineer	Dolby, Fraunhofer, L-Acoustics, broadcast R&D.
Immersive audio specialist	Atmos mixing, VR/AR audio, installation work.
Acoustic consultant	The reliable employer for the acoustics degrees — buildings, not music.

What it pays

Berlin	€45,000 – €65,000	indicative
aggregator (PayScale / SalaryExpert / ERI / Glassdoor) — medium — tracks the engineering band; Fraunhofer/industry R&D at the top		
Netherlands	€45,000 – €65,000	weak
aggregator (PayScale / SalaryExpert / ERI / Glassdoor) — low		
Spain	€22,000 – €35,000 (acoustic consulting)	indicative
Michael Page / Manfred salary guide 2026 (Spain) — medium		

The honest verdict

A genuinely scarce specialism, and acoustics consulting is a stable fallback that has nothing to do with music. Small field: few employers, so location follows the job.

Live Sound & Event Systems

What you would actually learn

- PA and line-array design, prediction software, system optimisation
- Show production: power, rigging, networked audio (Dante), safety
- This is learned on real shows more than in classrooms

What job you end up doing

Live sound engineer (FOH / monitors)	Touring or venue-based. Freelance is the norm.
Systems engineer / system tech	PA design and deployment — the technical top of the field.
Technical manager, venue or festival	The salaried destination.

What it pays

All three countries	no reliable figure retrieved	no data
— — none — and the degree does not exist here anyway		

The honest verdict

No viable master's exists in Spain, the Netherlands or Berlin — the Netherlands stops at bachelor and BHT Berlin admits only in the summer semester. Treat this as a certification and experience path alongside a degree, not as the degree.

Music Business & Management

What you would actually learn

- Rights, publishing, licensing and royalty flows — the actual mechanics of the industry
- Live and touring economics
- Streaming economics and playlist strategy
- Contract literacy, and negotiation

What job you end up doing

Label manager / A&R	The classic route. Berlin and Amsterdam are both real markets.
Rights and publishing manager	Less glamorous, more durable, better paid.
Artist manager / booking agent	Commission-based; income follows the roster.
Streaming / distribution analyst	Where your data skills would command a premium.

What it pays

Europe	no reliable European figures found	no data
— — NONE. The only benchmarks retrieved were US-denominated (junior A&R scout USD 40–60k, label marketing manager USD 70–130k) and do not transfer to Berlin, Amsterdam or Madrid pay scales		

The honest verdict

The weakest salary transparency of any path in this document, and that is itself the finding: music-business pay in Europe is not published, which usually means it is lower and more variable than the US figures circulating online. Your data skills are the differentiator that would move you up a band.

Music / Creative Entrepreneurship

What you would actually learn

- Venture creation, business models, funding and grant-writing
- Cultural policy and how public money moves in Europe
- Managing a practice as a business

What job you end up doing

Founder — label, studio, product, agency	The point of the path.
Cultural programme or venue manager	Salaried, often public or grant-funded.
Freelance portfolio career	Several part-incomes rather than one salary.

What it pays

All three

no salaried benchmark — income is what the venture earns

no data

— — none. Cultural-sector employed roles generally sit BELOW the national medians on page 1

The honest verdict

Do not choose this for the salary. Choose it if you intend to build something and want a year of runway, a network and a legal structure while you do. Note that ESMT's Panzer Scholarship (€35,000) requires exactly this founder profile.

Marketing & Brand Management

What you would actually learn

- Consumer behaviour and brand strategy
- Marketing analytics — regression, experiment design, attribution. Your maths is an advantage here
- Campaign and channel management
- Usually a company-based capstone project

What job you end up doing

Marketing analyst → marketing manager	The quantitative track is the one that fits you.
Growth / performance marketer	Closest to engineering; measurable, well-paid.
Brand manager	Slower, more corporate, more senior-track.

What it pays

Netherlands	€38,442 – €55,000 entry · €54,130 average	indicative
	PayScale + aggregator (PayScale / SalaryExpert / ERI / Glassdoor) — medium — but note SalaryExpert claims €100,432 average for the same role. A 2x disagreement	
Berlin	€45,000 – €60,000	indicative
	aggregator (PayScale / SalaryExpert / ERI / Glassdoor) — medium	
Spain	€22,000 – €35,000	indicative
	Michael Page / Manfred salary guide 2026 (Spain) — medium	

The honest verdict

The safety path: broad hiring, predictable pay, and quantitative marketing genuinely rewards your background. The cost is that it moves you furthest from music.

Media & Entertainment Management

What you would actually learn

- How media organisations are financed, structured and run
- Audience research and platform economics
- Creative-industries strategy and policy

What job you end up doing

Media / content operations manager	Streaming platforms, broadcasters, studios.
Creative-industries strategist or consultant	
Product or programme manager at a media company	Where your engineering re-enters the picture.

What it pays

Netherlands	€40,000 – €60,000	weak
aggregator (PayScale / SalaryExpert / ERI / Glassdoor) — low		
Berlin	€42,000 – €60,000	weak
aggregator (PayScale / SalaryExpert / ERI / Glassdoor) — low		
Spain	€22,000 – €32,000	weak
Michael Page / Manfred salary guide 2026 (Spain) — low		

The honest verdict

Sits between marketing and music business, and pays like the lower half of marketing. Most of these programmes also reject engineering backgrounds on subject grounds — check the pre-master requirement before you invest in this path.